

5 Spelling Tips to Improve Your Writing

Ready to become an English spelling wiz? In this lesson, I'm going to give you several important tips that will sharpen your spelling skills. We'll even look at some wacky news headlines to see these rules in action. Say goodbye to spelling slip-ups and hello to writing confidence. And don't forget about the quiz at the end to show off your spelling skills. Let's get cracking!

Is spelling important in our technological age?

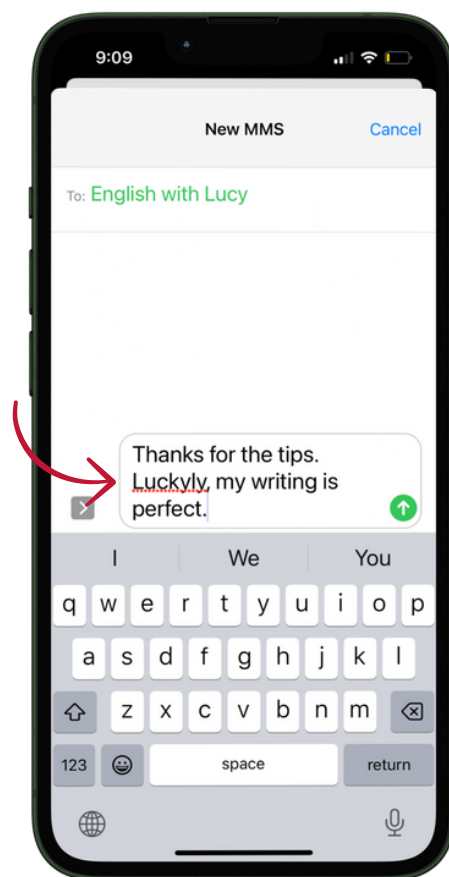
I know that many of us have **predictive text** and **spellcheckers** that highlight spelling errors and can help prevent embarrassing mistakes, but it's still worth dedicating a bit of time to learning some spelling rules.

Who knows when you might need to take accurate notes in English or perhaps you'll want to take an official language exam sometime in the future.

So, I have put together **five super helpful tips** that will allow you to improve your spelling in no time at all. And to help you master some of the key spelling rules, we're gonna take a look at some of today's top news stories.

***Disclaimer** - The hilarious headlines that follow are 100% not true!*

Let's take a look at the first headline from today's edition of the absolute best newspaper in the UK, **The EWL Gazette**. I actually read the first headline as I was drinking my morning cappuccino.



● HEADLINE 1

Sip, Sip Hooray! Caffeine receives scientists' backing as the 'espresso' route to higher patient and client satisfaction

Do you get it? 'Sip, Sip, Hooray' instead of 'Hip, Hip, Hooray'? 'Espresso route' instead of 'express route'? I love wordplay in English - you'll often find a lot of similar **puns** in headlines.

Rule 1: 'i' before 'e' except after 'c'

This humorous headline illustrates our first spelling rule: **'i' before 'e' except after 'c'**. It's one of the very first spelling rules I learnt at school - probably because it rhymes and is quite catchy. But what does it mean?

Well, when we write a word with the letters 'i' and 'e' next to each other, we usually put the 'i' first - **'i' before 'e'**. We saw this in the headline with the words:

- pati**ent**
- cli**ent**

Here are some more common words that follow this rule:

- fri**end**
- nie**ce**
- thie**f**
- revie**w**

The second part of the rule is **except after 'c'**. This means that after the letter 'c', the order switches and we write 'ei'. We saw this with the word -



- rece**ive**

Here are a few more examples:

- rece**ipt**
- perce**ive**
- dece**it**
- ce**iling**

But this is English and there are *always* exceptions! In fact, we saw a couple in the headline with the word **caffeine**, which is spelt '**ei**' and the word **scientists**, which is spelt '**cie**.'

Here are some more examples of exceptions to this rule.

Exceptions to 'i' before 'e' except after 'c'

Words spelt 'ei'		Words spelt 'cie'	
we ir d	fore ei gn	soci et y	anci en t
prote i n	he i ght	effi ci ent	defi ci ent
Names: Ne i l, Ke i th	ne i ther	speci es	consci en ce
leis ur e	neigh bour	sci en ce	coeffi ci ent
weigh h	seiz e	suffi ci ent	pres ci ent

Of all the rules I'm going to teach you today, this is perhaps the one that has the most exceptions. If in doubt, make sure you double check spelling in a dictionary.

Let's move on to the second headline that caught my attention.



HEADLINE 2

Rats dismayed as butterflies declared prettiest creature on subways

Now this one left me a little confused. I've seen quite a few rats on the London Underground, but never any butterflies, sadly.

The second spelling rule I want to show you is this: if a word ends in a consonant plus the letter 'y', we change the 'y' into 'i' before adding a suffix.

Rule 2: Consonant + y → i

In English, we have five vowels: **a**, **e**, **i**, **o** and **u**. All the other letters are consonants. A **suffix** is a letter or letters added to the end of a word to create a new word.

Let's look at one of the nouns in our headline. '**Butterfly**' ends in the consonant '**t**' plus the letter '**y**'. So, if we want to make the word plural, as we saw in the headline, we need to **change the 'y' into 'i'** before adding the suffix '**-es**.' Notice how we need to add 'es' to form the plural of this word - not 's'.

- butterfly**s** ✗
- butterfly**s** ✗
- butterfly**ies** ✓

We also saw this change with the adjective **pretty**. Pretty ends in the consonant '**t**' plus '**y**', so the comparative and superlative forms are **prettier** and **prettiest**.

pretty → **prettier** → **prettiest**



We change the 'y' to 'i' and then add the suffix. Here are some more examples -

- lucky + -ly → luckily
- marry + -age → marriage
- try + -ed → tried
- cry + es → cries
- party + es → parties

Remember, with this rule, we add **-es**, not **-s**, to form the plural and third-person singular.

Be careful when adding the suffix **-ing**. We don't normally like to have two 'i's together, so keep the 'y' when adding -ing.

- fly + -ing → fly**ing** ✓ fly**ii**ng ✗
- try + -ing → try**ing** ✓ try**ii**ng ✗

Speaking of eyes, don't forget to keep your eye out for exceptions! Yes, in English we even have exceptions to exceptions! One of the most common is in the word **'skiing'**.

- ski + -ing → ski**ing** ✓ sky**ing** ✗

This one often catches my students out! I've heard this word pronounced **sky-ing** /'skaiɪŋ/ so many times; the correct pronunciation is **/'ski:ɪŋ/**. So, take care with the pronunciation - and spelling here!

Another exception is the word **'taxiing'**.

- taxi + -ing → taxi**ing** ✓ taxy**ing** ✗

Remember, if a word ends in a **vowel + y**, there's no need to change the letter 'y'. We also keep the 'y' with possessives, e.g. Andy**y's**, bunny**y's**, etc.



For example, the words **dismay** and **subway** from our headline both end in a vowel + y, so the 'y' stays.

- dismay + -ed → dismay**ed**
- subway + -s → subway**s**

Here are some more examples -

- jersey + -s → jersey**s**
- buy + -s → buy**s**
- survey + -ed → survey**ed**
- enjoy + -ed → enjoy**ed**

Be careful, though. There are several exceptions to this, which we can see in some very common '**ay**' words, for example, **daily**, **paid** and **said**.

- day + -ly → **daily**
- pay + -ed → **paid**
- say + -ed → **said**

There are also a number of short words with only one syllable which keep the 'y' too, for example -

- dry + -ness → dry**ness**
- shy + -er → shy**er**
- fry + -er → fry**er**
- sly + -ly → sly**ly**

Ready for another headline?

HEADLINE 3

Beginner's luck? Upset judges suspect foul play as spelling bee winner is spotted checking phone

Surely they shouldn't have allowed phones in the competition! Well, by the end of today's lesson, you'll be ready to enter a spelling competition with no cheating necessary!

This headline clearly illustrates our next spelling rule. When a word ends in a **consonant, vowel, consonant pattern** we double the final consonant before adding a suffix. Consonant plus vowel plus consonant is often shortened to **CVC**.

Rule 3: CVC (Consonant + vowel + consonant) → double the final consonant

We usually do this with one-syllable words when we add a suffix that begins with a vowel. Some of the most common suffixes to consider here are **-ing**, **-ed**, **-er**, **-or** and **-est**.

In the headline, we saw the words **winner** and **spotted**. The base or root forms of both these words end in a consonant, vowel, consonant, or CVC pattern. So, the final consonant is doubled when we add a suffix beginning with a vowel.

- win + -er → winne**er**
- spot + -ed → spotted**ed**

Here are more common examples -

big + -er → bigg <u>e</u> r	rub + -ing → rub <u>b</u> i ng	hot + -est → hott <u>e</u> s t	drop + -ed → dropp <u>e</u> d	chat + -ed → chatt <u>e</u> d
---------------------------------------	--	--	---	---

This rule also applies when adding the suffix **-y**.

- mum + -y → mummy
- dad + -y → daddy
- sun + -y → sunny

We **don't** normally double the consonant when we add a suffix that begins with a consonant - for example, **-s** or **-ness**.

- plan + -s → plans ✓ planns ✗
- fit + -ness → fitness ✓ fittness ✗

We also often **double the final consonant** with words that are stressed on the 2nd syllable. For example -

- beGIN + -er → beginner
- upSET + -ing → upsetting
- reFER + -al → referral

We **don't** usually double the consonant if the word is stressed on the **first syllable**.

- OFFer + -ed → offered
- VISit + -or → visitor
- open + -ing → opening

There are, of course, some exceptions to this rule. One important exception is that in British English, we sometimes **double the final 'l'** even when the stress is on the first syllable. In American English, a single 'l' is generally preferred.

British English		American English	
TRAVel + -er →	travell <u>e</u> r	TRAVel + -er →	travel <u>e</u> r
LAbeL + -ing →	labell <u>i</u> ng	LAbeL + -ing →	label <u>i</u> ng
CANcel + -ed →	cancell <u>e</u> d	CANcel + -ed →	cancel <u>e</u> d

In American English, a **single 'l' is generally preferred**. We'll take a look at a few more differences between British and American spelling a bit later.

What other headlines are on the front page of today's paper?

● HEADLINE 4

Content creator faces backlash after freely admitting to using pets as writers.

Now, I absolutely swear this isn't me. I love Diego dearly, but he only ever provides me with inspiration...and snuggles.

Rule 4: Drop the final 'e' when adding a suffix that begins with a vowel.

Moving swiftly on to explain the next rule.....We often drop the final -e when we add a suffix beginning with a vowel. We've already seen some common suffixes that begin with vowels such as **-er**, **-est**, **-or** and **-ing**. In this headline we have the following words -

- create + -or → creator
- use + -ing → using
- write + -er → writers



Of course, there are exceptions to this rule. We don't drop silent 'e' to maintain the soft sound of 'c' or 'g' before suffixes like '-able' or '-ous'.

- manage + -able → manageable
- courage + -ous → couraeous

You will also notice differences in British and American English, where the 'e' is often kept in certain words in British English but omitted in American English.

British English		American English	
mile + -age →	mile <u>a</u> ge	mile + -age →	mil <u>a</u> ge
age + -ing →	age <u>i</u> ng	age + -ing →	agi <u>n</u> g

We don't normally drop the 'e' if the suffix begins with a consonant, like -

- free + -ly → freely
- use + -ful → useful
- agree + -ment → agreement

As always, there are exceptions. For example, we **remove the 'e'** from argue to make the noun argument.

- argue + -ment → arguement

We also sometimes have **alternative spellings** to help us tell the difference between words. For example, 'to die' as in the opposite of 'to live' and 'to dye' as in 'to colour your hair'.

- die + -ing → dying
- dye + -ing → dyeing

Let's move on to our final and perhaps most bizarre headline.



● HEADLINE 5

Ape creates new app by hugging huge hat in bathtub.

Rule 5: When there is a silent 'e' at the end of the word, the vowel before it is pronounced like the letter in the alphabet.

Now, I'm super excited about rule number 5 because, to explain it, we're going to take a brief dive into pronunciation.

Yes! Normally, when a word has a **CVC**, or **consonant + vowel + consonant** pattern, the vowel in the middle is pronounced with a short sound, for example:

- **æ** - hat - /hæt/
- **e** - pet - /pet/
- **ɪ** - win - /wɪn/
- **ɒ** - not - /nɒt/
- **ʌ** - hug - /hʌg/

If there is a **silent 'e'** at the end of the word, the vowel sound changes and is pronounced the same as the letter from the alphabet - **a, e, i, o, u**.

So the '**a**' /æ/ in 'hat' becomes /eɪ/ in 'hate' /heɪt/, the /e/ in 'pet' becomes /i:/ in 'Pete', and so on. Practise these words, paying close attention to how the vowel sounds change.

hat /hæt/ → hate /heɪt/

pet /pet/ → Pete /pi:t/

win /wɪn/ → wine /waɪn/

not /nɒt/ → note /nəʊt/

hug /hʌg/ → huge /hju:dʒ/



This spelling rule can really help you, especially if you hear the word before you've ever seen it written!

Now, that's all we've got from the headlines, but I have a couple more tips I'm gonna go through super quickly because they're going to help you make big improvements to your spelling accuracy.

Extra tip 1: Learn common consonant clusters

English is jam-packed with consonant clusters. A consonant cluster is a group of consonants with no vowel in between. It's a really good idea to learn how to spell and recognise common clusters like '**ght**'. We find this cluster in many irregular past simple and past participle forms, such as **bought**, **thought**, **caught**, and **fought**.

We also find it in other common words, like

- **right**
- **tonight**
- **eight**
- **height**

Notice how the letters '**gh**' aren't pronounced? They are **silent** and this can make spelling these words correctly particularly challenging.

We have lots of silent letters in English. Here are some common ones.

b	c	d	g	h	k
doubt, subtle, thumb	scissors, muscle, scene	Wednesday, edge	gnaw, sign, foreign	honest, ghost, heir	knee, know, knife
l	n	p	s	t	w
would, should, calf	autumn, column, hymn	psychology, receipt	island, aisle, debris	castle, match, Christmas	wrist, wreck, answer

It's a great idea to keep a record as you come across these words so you don't get caught out when writing! Noticing silent letters will help you improve your pronunciation accuracy, too.

Extra Tip 2: American or British

My final tip for you is to be aware of the differences in American and British spelling. We've already seen a couple of examples of this, but there are quite a few more differences I'd like to draw your attention to!

It doesn't really matter which spelling you choose, but you should try to be consistent, especially if you're taking a formal exam. Here are some common differences -

In American English, most people tend to drop the 'u' in words that are spelt with the letters '-our' in British English. For example -

British English - our vs American English - or	
British English	American English
colour	color
favour	favor
neighbourhood	neighborhood

In American English, a 'z' often replaces the 's' in many words ending in 'ise'. This also happens with the cluster 'yse', like in 'analyse'. Let's take a look:

British English -ise or -ize vs American English -ize	
British English	American English
organise	organize
apologise	apologize
analyse	analyze

In British English, both spellings are acceptable - just remember to try and stay consistent.

In British English, some words that are spelt with a **single 'l'**, like **enrol** and **fulfil**, are spelt with a **double 'll'** in American English.

British English single 'l' vs American English double 'll'	
British English	American English
enrol	enroll
fulfil	fulfill
wilful	willful
instalment	installment

What is it with us and the Americans and the letter 'l'? We write one, they write two, then they write two, so we write one!

Some of the Most Commonly Misspelt Words in English

Word	Explanation
accommodation	Often misspelt as 'accomodation' or 'acommodation' due to confusion over the number of 'c's and 'm's.
calendar	Often misspelt as 'calender' or 'calandar' due to confusion over the middle vowel and the misleading 'ar' ending.
definitely	Commonly misspelt as 'definitely' or 'definitly,' possibly because of the way it's pronounced in some accents, leading to confusion about the internal 'i'.
embarrass	Misspelt as 'embarass' or 'embarras' because of uncertainty about the number of 'r's and 's's.
February	Often spelt as 'Febuary,' likely because the first 'r' is silent.
maintenance	Often spelt as 'maintainance,' likely because it's derived from the verb 'maintain', leading to a direct (but incorrect) transfer of the verb's spelling pattern.
necessary	Often misspelt as 'neccessary', 'necesity' or 'nessessary' because of the confusion over the number of 'c's and 's's.
occasion	Frequently misspelt as 'ocassion' or 'occassion' due to uncertainty about the correct number of 'c's and 's's.
privilege	Commonly misspelt as 'priviledge', 'privelege' or 'privilage' because of the ambiguous middle vowel sound and the 'dge' ending.
separate	Frequently misspelt as 'seperate,' possibly because of the way it's pronounced, leading to confusion about the 'a' in the middle.
successful	Often misspelt as 'succesful' or 'successfull' due to uncertainty about the number of 'c's and 's's and the final 'l'.
tomorrow	Commonly misspelt as 'tommorow' or 'tomorow,' likely because of uncertainty about the number of 'm's and 'r's.



QUIZ!

Choose the correct answer for each question.

1. Turn 'argue' into a noun by adding a suffix: 'argu____'.

- a. arguement
- b. argument
- c. argumint

2. Choose the correct American English spelling:

- a. colour
- b. color
- c. colur

3. Which word is spelt correctly?

- a. beginer
- b. begining
- c. beginner

4. Choose the plural form of 'butterfly':

- a. butterflys
- b. butterflyies
- c. butterflies

5. Change the word 'fly' to its gerund form: 'fl____ing'.

- a. flyng
- b. fliing
- c. flying

6. What is the correct spelling for the superlative form of 'big'?

- a. biggest
- b. biggestt
- c. igestt

7. How should 'die' be spelt when adding '-ing'?

- a. dying
- b. dieing
- c. dyng

8. I received a beautiful bouquet of flowers, which truly _____ my day.

- a. brightend
- b. brightened
- c. brightenned

9. The _____ puppy wagged its tail excitedly as we walked into the room.

- a. happiest
- b. happyest
- c. happyiest

10. 'Cries' is the correct plural form of 'cry'.

- a. True
- b. False

The End!

1) b 2) b 3) c 4) c 5) c 6) b 7) a 8) b 9) a 10) a

